



Louise Thomson
THE PLAYBOOK

THE COMPLETE GUIDE · 2026

CREATOR · SOCIAL MEDIA MANAGER · BUSINESS OWNER

The Complete Creator Playbook

Everything I did to go from a 9–5 to a full-time creator and business — written like I'm sat next to you talking you through it. No fluff, no gatekeeping.

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START HERE

Read this first (properly).

Okay — real talk. Two years ago I was sat in a job I couldn't stand, refreshing my banking app on a Sunday night, wondering how everyone online seemed to be making money from their phone except me.

I wasn't special. No following, no savings, no clue. What I had was a phone and a stubborn refusal to believe a 9–5 was it. This guide is everything I worked out — the messy way — so you don't have to. It's literally what I did, step by step.

You don't need to be famous, techy or lucky. You need one skill people pay for, a simple system, and the stubbornness to keep going when it's slow. That's the whole secret.

Four rules before we start

- ✦ **Don't just read it.** Reading feels productive — it isn't. Every bit ends with one thing to actually do. Do that thing.
- ✦ **Pick ONE path first.** Creator, social media manager, or your own thing. I tried all three at once and got nowhere — don't be me.
- ✦ **Let it be scrappy.** Your first videos will be bad. Mine were shocking. Post them anyway — that's how you get good.
- ✦ **Keep it close.** The pricing, scripts and checklists — you'll want them the day a client says yes and you slightly panic (you will, it's fine).

I won't lie to you: you won't be rich by Friday. But do the things in here and you'll make your first money online — and once you've made £1, £10k is just the same skills on repeat. Right — let's go.



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WHAT'S INSIDE

Twelve modules — the whole industry.

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How it flows: learn to create & get found (1–3), turn it into paid client work & an agency (4–5), look professional (6–7), price & set the business up properly (8–9), then grow, launch and scale — with my team and AI behind you (10–12).



A woman with long brown hair, wearing a leopard-print dress, is sitting at a bar. She is looking towards the camera with a slight smile. Her right arm is raised, resting her head on her hand. The bar has a marble top and a backlit shelf filled with various liquor bottles. The lighting is warm and dim, creating a sophisticated atmosphere.

MODULE 01

Foundations & Mindset

Before any tactics — the opportunity you're walking into, the three ways to actually earn, how to pick your thing, and the number you're aiming at. Get this bit right and the rest is easy.

The opportunity

Your path

Your niche

Your goal



THE OPPORTUNITY

You're early, not late.

Everyone tells you "you've missed it, it's too saturated." Rubbish. I hear that every single year — and every single year more people quit their jobs doing this. You're not late. You're early to the rest of your life.

£0

To start — you own the kit already

2–3 hrs

A day is enough on the side

Global

Your market is the whole internet

Why this actually works right now

- ✦ **Every business needs content and hasn't got a clue.** That gap is literally your income — they'll happily pay you to fix it.
- ✦ **Attention is money.** If you can make someone stop scrolling, you can turn that into cash a dozen different ways.
- ✦ **The tools are free.** The same phone in your hand built my whole business. No studio, no team, no budget.
- ✦ **You start tiny.** One client, one video, one product — then it snowballs. It always starts small.

Reframe it: you're not "trying to go viral." You're building a **skill** — content, growth, managing socials — that the market pays for whether you've got 500 followers or 5 million.

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YOUR PATH

Three ways to earn — pick one.

There are three routes in. They overlap and honestly I do all three now — but when you're starting, pick **ONE**. Trying all three at once is how you end up doing none properly (been there).



Content Creator

Grow your own audience, get paid through brand deals, UGC and your own stuff.

If you want a personal brand



Social Media Manager

Run socials for other businesses for a monthly fee. Money the fastest.

If you want cash soonest



Business Owner

Package it all — agency, websites, products — into a company.

If you want to scale big

Which one, honestly?

- ✦ **Need money in 30 days?** Start as a **social media manager**. You can land a paying client before you have any following at all.
- ✦ **Love being on camera?** Start as a **creator**, then add management once you get how the platforms work.
- ✦ **Already got a skill or a following?** Go straight to **business owner** and package it up.

Do this now: circle the one that's you today. That's the module you start with — but read the lot, because you'll end up doing more than one.

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YOUR NICHE

Get specific — it's how you get paid.

"I'll just post about everything" is the fastest way to grow nothing. I know because I did it. The second I got specific, everything clicked — people knew what I was for, so they followed, and brands knew who to book.

My little formula: Passion × Skill × Demand. Something you actually enjoy, something you're half-decent at (or willing to learn), and something people already spend money on. Where those three cross — that's your niche.

Niches that make money

- ◆ Beauty & skincare
- ◆ Fitness & wellness
- ◆ Fashion & styling
- ◆ Food & recipes
- ◆ Travel & lifestyle
- ◆ Home & interiors
- ◆ Money & business
- ◆ Parenting & family
- ◆ Local businesses (huge for SMM)
- ◆ Tech, gaming & AI

Now nail it down in one line

Fill this in: **"I help [who] to [what] through [content / social media]."** e.g. "I help busy mums eat well in 15 minutes" or "I help local gyms fill their classes." That one sentence is your whole positioning — it goes in your bio, your pitches, everywhere.

Do this now: write your one-liner. If a stranger can't tell what you do from it, make it more specific.

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YOUR GOAL

Aim at a real number.

"I want to make money online" isn't a goal, it's a wish. Pick an actual number and work backwards — the internet doesn't cap your income, so the target's yours to set.

The income ladder (pick your rung)

Level	What it looks like	Monthly
Side money	1 SMM client or a few UGC videos	£500–£1,000
Part-time	2–3 clients or steady brand deals	£1,500–£3,000
Full-time	Replace the 9–5, streams mixed	£4,000–£8,000
Scaling	Agency / products / big deals	£10,000–£20,000+

Now work backwards

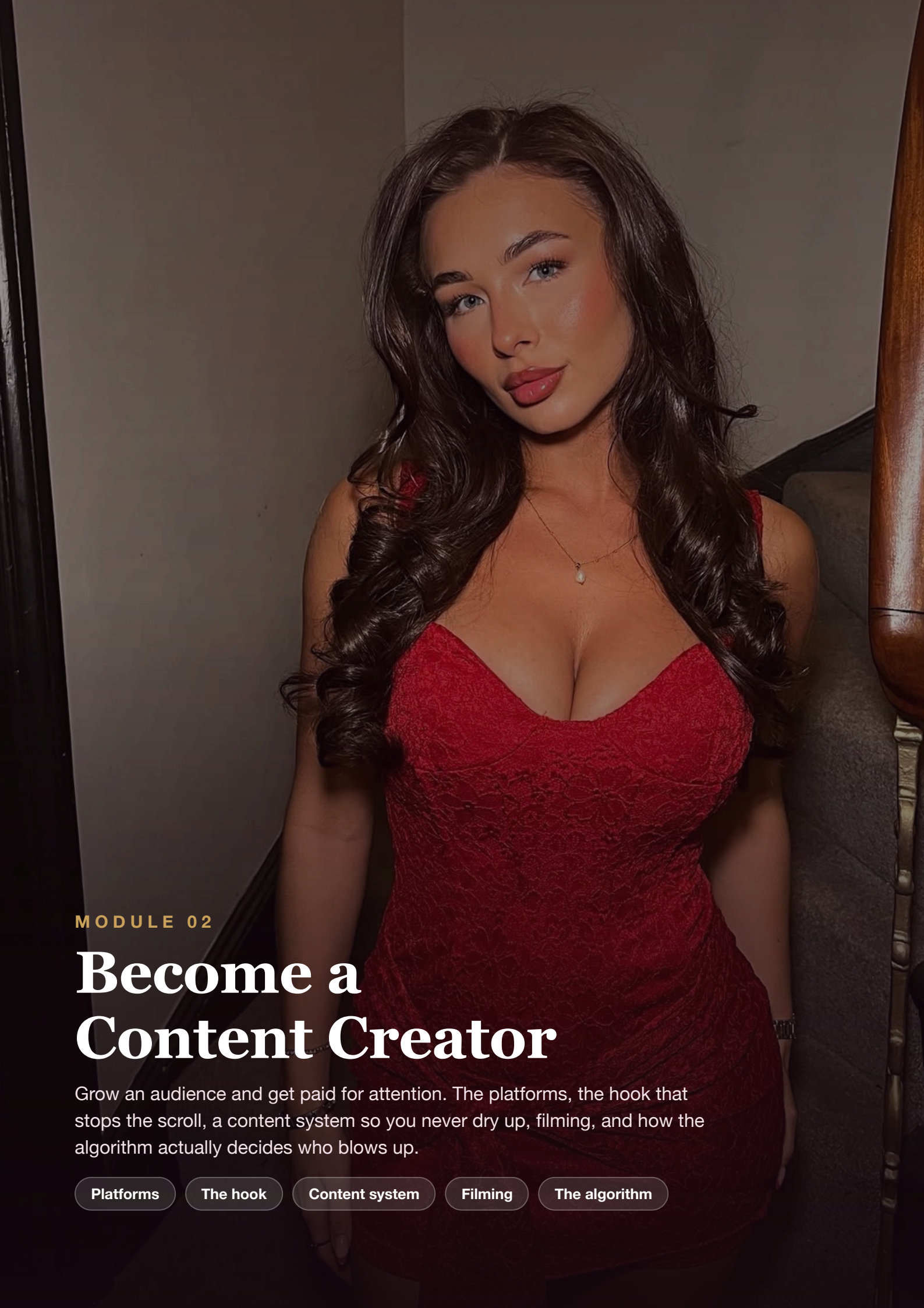
- ✦ Want **£2,000 a month**? That's just **2 clients at £1,000**. Or 8–10 UGC videos. Or one good brand deal a week. Suddenly it's not scary.
- ✦ Break the money into **things you can count** — clients, videos, deals — and chase the **things**, not the money. The money follows.

Your income is a decision, not a wage.

Nobody's giving you a raise. Here, you give yourself one — you add a client, a stream, or you put your prices up.

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MODULE 02

Become a Content Creator

Grow an audience and get paid for attention. The platforms, the hook that stops the scroll, a content system so you never dry up, filming, and how the algorithm actually decides who blows up.

Platforms

The hook

Content system

Filming

The algorithm

THE ROLE

What the job actually is.

A creator does two things: makes stuff people want to watch, and builds trust with the people watching. That's it. Everything else — deals, sales, clients — comes off the back of those two.

Where to post (and why)



TikTok

Fastest growth from zero — it shows new creators to new people. Start here.



Instagram

Where brands look and money lives. Reels for reach, feed & stories for trust.



YouTube

Slower, but it compounds — long life and searchable for years.

Start on ONE (I'd say TikTok), get good, then repurpose the same content everywhere. One idea → a TikTok, a Reel, a Short, a post. Don't try to be everywhere on day one.

Your week, on repeat

- ♦ **Plan** — pull the week's ideas from your pillars (coming up).
- ♦ **Batch** — film a few in one go. 10× more efficient than filming daily.
- ♦ **Post & reply** — answer every comment in the first hour, it tells the app your video's hot.
- ♦ **Review** — see what worked, do more of that. Simple.

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Want more, or want it done for you? [DM @lou1sethomson](https://www.instagram.com/lou1sethomson)

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THE HOOK SYSTEM

The first 2 seconds are everything.

Here's the truth nobody wants to hear: right now, nobody cares about your video. You've got about **two seconds** before the thumb keeps scrolling — and if you don't stop them there, it doesn't matter how good the rest is, because no one sees it. So we obsess over those two seconds. This one skill changed everything for me.

How to write a hook that actually stops people

- 1 Lead with the result or the drama — never the setup**
Bin "hey guys so today I wanted to talk about..." (instant scroll). Open with "I made £2,000 from one video — here's exactly how."
- 2 Put the promise on screen in frame one**
People watch on mute. If they can read what they'll get in the first second, they stay. Big text, top third.
- 3 Open a loop — don't give the answer yet**
"The third one is the reason I blew up..." Their brain needs to close the loop, so they keep watching.

Steal these — fill in the blanks

- ♦ "Stop **[mistake]** if you want **[result]**."
- ♦ "Nobody tells you this about **[topic]**..."
- ♦ "I tried **[thing]** for 30 days — here's what happened."
- ♦ "How I went from **[before]** to **[after]**."

My actual process: I write 10 hooks before I film anything. I bin 7. I film the 3 that make even *me* want to watch. Weak hook? I don't post it. No hook, no post.

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CONTENT SYSTEM

Never run out of ideas.

Consistency beats everything, and the thing that kills consistency is sitting there going "what do I even post today?" A simple system fixes that forever. Mine is pillars + a set week.

Step 1 — pick 3–5 pillars

Pillars are the themes you always post about. Example for a fitness page: **Educate** (tips, myths), **Inspire** (wins, transformations), **Relate** (day-in-the-life, struggles), **Sell** (your offer). Everything you post is one of these.

The 3:1 rule: for every 3 posts that give value, 1 can sell. Give way more than you ask for and people happily buy when you do ask.

Step 2 — set a repeatable week

Day	Pillar	Format
Mon	Educate	Quick talking-head tip
Wed	Relate	Day-in-the-life
Fri	Inspire	A result / story
Sun	Sell / trend	Your offer or a trending sound

Do this now: write your 4 pillars, then batch-film one video for each in a single 90-minute session. That's your whole week done.

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FILMING & EDITING

Make it look pro on a phone.

You do not need a fancy camera. I still film everything on my phone. You need three things: decent light, clear sound, clean edits. That's the whole game.

The £0–£100 kit

- ✦ **Your phone** — the camera's plenty good
- ✦ **A window** or a cheap ring light
- ✦ **A phone tripod** (~£15)
- ✦ **A clip mic** for talking videos (~£25)

Free editing apps

- ✦ **CapCut** — the industry standard, free
- ✦ **InShot** — quick and simple
- ✦ Or edit in-app and post natively

My editing checklist (every video)

- ✓ **Captions on** — most people watch on mute.
- ✓ **Cut every pause** — trim the dead air, keep it snappy.
- ✓ **Hook text in the first frame.**
- ✓ **Trending or clean audio.**
- ✓ **Vertical, full screen** — 9:16, no borders.

Real talk: done beats perfect, every time. Your 50th video will be miles better than your first — so get to your 50th fast. Stop overthinking one video.

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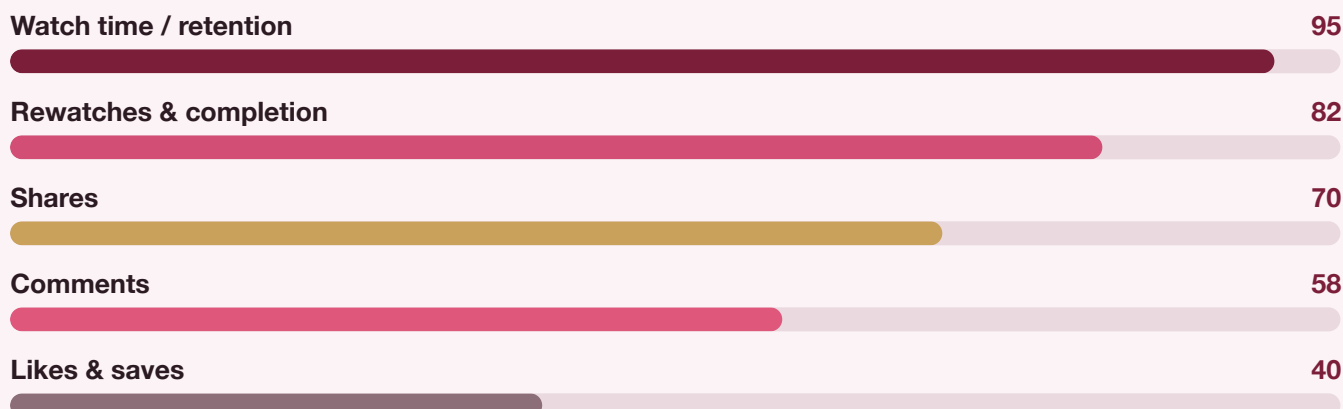


THE ALGORITHM

How you actually blow up.

The algorithm isn't magic and it isn't out to get you. It shows your video to a small test group, watches how they react, and pushes the winners to more people. Your whole job is to win that first little test.

The signals that matter (in order)



- ★ **Hook for retention** — the longer they watch, the more it spreads. Everything comes back to watch time.
- ★ **Make it shareable** — a share is the strongest signal. Give people a reason to send it to a mate.
- ★ **Reply to comments fast** — early engagement tells it your video's hot.
- ★ **Post consistently** — 1× a day beats 7× on Monday then nothing.
- ★ **Ride trends early** — trending sounds and formats get a boost.

Don't chase followers — chase reach. Views bring the followers, the deals and the clients. One video really can change your life; I've had **18.3M likes on a single post.**

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IDEAS & REPURPOSING

One idea, a whole week.

Two things kill people: running out of ideas, and burning out making them. Here's the bank I pull from, and how I turn one idea into a week of content so I'm not filming every single day.

10 ideas that always work

- ◆ How-to / tutorial
- ◆ Common mistakes in your niche
- ◆ Myth vs truth
- ◆ Day in the life
- ◆ Before & after
- ◆ "Things I wish I knew"
- ◆ Answer a follower question
- ◆ A product/tool you love
- ◆ Story time (a lesson)
- ◆ A trend, done your way

Turn 1 idea into 5 posts

1 Pick one topic
e.g. "how I plan a week of content."

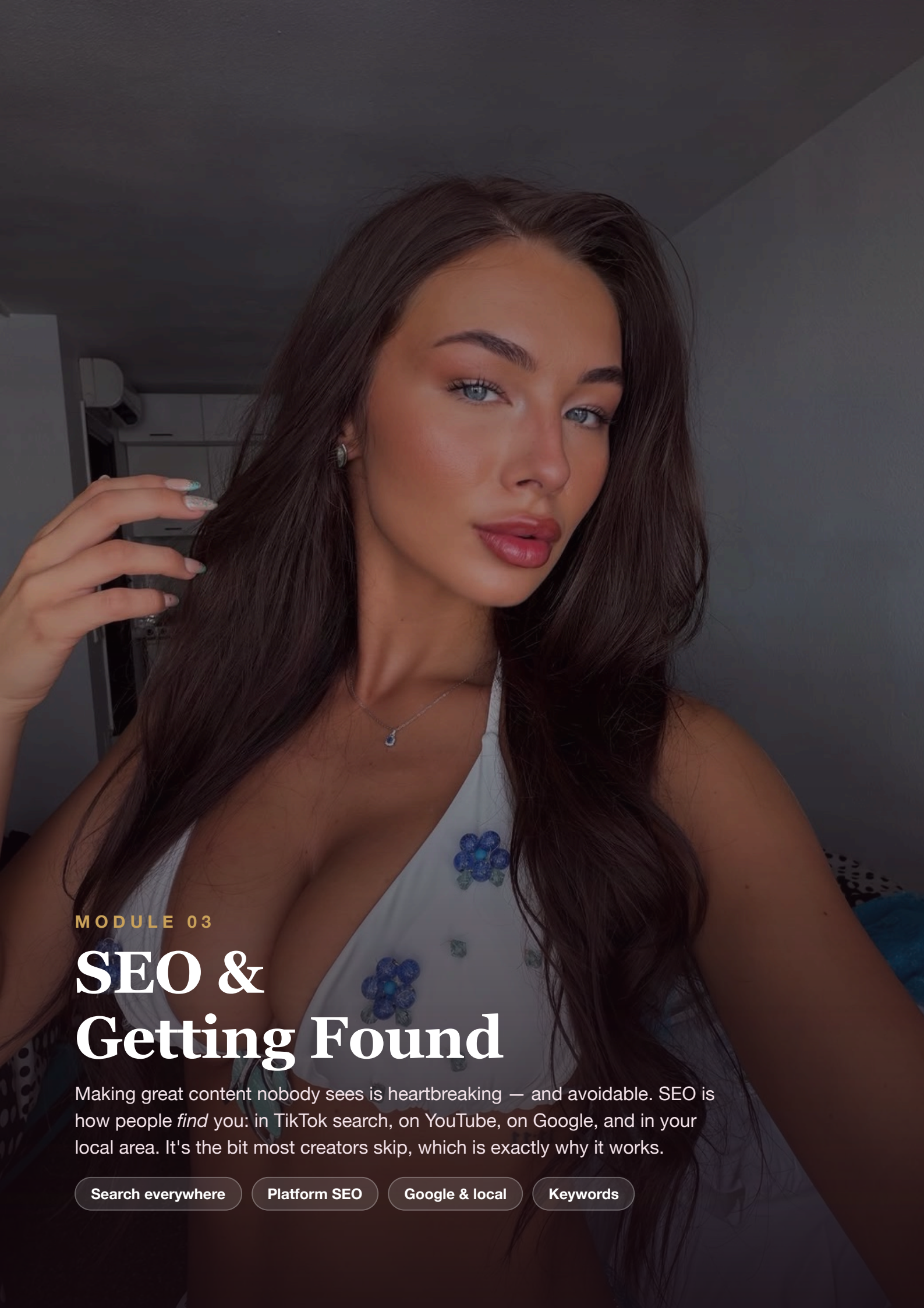
2 Chop it up
The quick tip, the full how-to, the mistake to avoid, a result, a Q&A.

3 Reformat
Video, carousel, story, a written post, an email — same idea, five places.

Do this now: start a notes list called "content ideas" and dump every idea into it the second it hits you. You'll never open the app with nothing to say again.

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MODULE 03

SEO & Getting Found

Making great content nobody sees is heartbreaking — and avoidable. SEO is how people *find* you: in TikTok search, on YouTube, on Google, and in your local area. It's the bit most creators skip, which is exactly why it works.

Search everywhere

Platform SEO

Google & local

Keywords



WHY SEO

Get found, not just seen.

Most creators only think about the feed. The smart ones think about **search** too. Every day millions of people search TikTok, YouTube and Google for exactly what you do — SEO puts you in front of them on autopilot, months after you posted.

Feed vs search — why search wins long-term

- ✦ **Feed content** spikes then dies in about 48 hours.
- ✦ **Search content** keeps getting found for months and years — it stacks up.
- ✦ **Intent is higher** — someone searching "best gym in Glasgow" is ready to buy, not just scrolling.

The 3 layers of getting found



Platform search

Ranking inside TikTok, Instagram & YouTube search.



Google & web

Your site & YouTube showing on Google.



Local

Getting found by people near you — gold for clients.



Want a keyword plan for your niche or a client's business? **DM @lou1sethomson.**

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Want more, or want it done for you? **DM @lou1sethomson**

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PLATFORM SEO

Rank inside the apps.

TikTok, Instagram and YouTube are search engines now — people literally use them like Google. Here's how to rank so your content keeps getting found long after you post.

The rules that apply everywhere

- ♦ **Say your keyword out loud** in the first few seconds — the apps transcribe your audio and file the video by it.
- ♦ **Put the keyword in your on-screen text AND caption.**
- ♦ **Use words people actually type** — "high-protein breakfast", not "yummy morning fuel."

App	Ranks on	Do this
TikTok	Spoken words, captions, tags	Keyword in line 1 + say it
Instagram	Captions, name field, alt text	Keywords in caption & name
YouTube	Title, description, tags	Keyword title + full description

Sneaky tip: your Instagram **name field** (not your @handle) is searchable. Put your niche there — "Ella · Glasgow Content & Social" — and you'll show up when people search it.

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GOOGLE & LOCAL

Own Google & your area.

A website plus a Google presence makes you look real and gets you found by people ready to hire. And local SEO? That's a goldmine if you're chasing local clients as a social media manager.

Website SEO basics

- ✦ **One keyword per page** — in the title, the first heading, and the URL.
- ✦ **Write for humans first**, then slot keywords in naturally.
- ✦ **Fast & mobile** — Google ranks quick, mobile-friendly sites higher.

Local SEO (clients love this)

- ✦ **Google Business Profile** — free, and it sticks a business on the map. Setting these up is a paid service you can offer.
- ✦ **Reviews** — more 5-stars = higher local ranking.
- ✦ **Local keywords** — "[service] in [town]" across the site and posts.

Easy money idea: offer local businesses a "get found on Google" package — profile setup, a reviews system, local content. £300–£800, and most owners have no idea how to do it.

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KEYWORDS & HASHTAGS

Words that get you found.

Keywords and hashtags are how the apps understand what your content is and who to show it to. Use them on purpose, not randomly slapped on the end.

Find your keywords (free, 5 mins)

- ✦ **Type into the search bar** — the autocomplete suggestions are literally what people search. Gold.
- ✦ **Check "others searched for"** under the results.
- ✦ **Read your comments** — the questions people ask ARE keywords.

The hashtag formula

- ✦ **3–5 focused tags** beat 30 random ones.
- ✦ **Mix the sizes** — 1 big, 2 medium (your niche), 1 small/branded.
- ✦ **Make a branded hashtag** that's yours alone — so your world's easy to find.

Captions are SEO too. Open with your keyword, write a real sentence a human would search, then your call to action. Half my "views" come from search, not the feed.

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MODULE 04

Become a Social Media Manager

The fastest way to real money — honestly. You don't need a following, you need a service and a system. This module is find clients, pitch them, close them, deliver like a pro, and keep them paying you every month.

The services

Find clients

Pitch & close

Deliver

Keep them



THE ROLE

Get paid to run their socials.

Here's the bit people miss: you can earn as a social media manager **with zero followers of your own**. Businesses know they need social media and have no time or clue. You run it for them for a monthly fee. Recurring, reliable money — my favourite kind.

What you actually offer

- ✦ **Content** — posts, reels, stories
- ✦ **Scheduling & posting**
- ✦ **Captions & hashtags**
- ✦ **Replying to comments & DMs**
- ✦ **Strategy & a plan**
- ✦ **Filming days** at their place
- ✦ **Paid ads** (add-on, more money)
- ✦ **A monthly report**

They pay for the outcome — more customers, a page that looks legit — **not your personal follower count**. So don't wait until you're "big enough." You're ready now.

Who to go after first

- ✦ **Local businesses** — gyms, salons, cafés, dentists, trades, restaurants.
- ✦ **Small brands** posting rubbish or nothing.
- ✦ **Coaches & service people** — great at their thing, hopeless at posting.

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FIND CLIENTS

Where they're hiding.

You don't need hundreds of leads. You need a handful of the right conversations. Here's exactly where to look and how to open the door without being cringe.

Where to find them

- ✦ **Instagram search** — local businesses with dead or ugly pages. That's your opening line right there.
- ✦ **Google Maps** — every business near you, loads with no socials linked.
- ✦ **Your own network** — your fastest first client is someone who already knows you.
- ✦ **Local Facebook groups** — small business owners live in there.

The DM that actually works

Lead with value, not a pitch. Point out one thing you'd improve, or send a free idea. Make it about them, not you.

"Hi [name], love what you do at [business]! I put together a couple of quick content ideas that could bring you more [bookings/customers] — want me to send them over? No strings, I just work with local businesses like yours."

- ✦ **Follow up twice.** Most yeses are in the follow-up, not the first message.
- ✦ **Aim for a call, not a sale,** in the DM. You sell on the call.

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PITCH & CLOSE

Turn a chat into a client.

On the call you're not begging for work. You're a professional looking at their problem and telling them the fix. Confidence closes — and this simple structure does the heavy lifting.

- 1 Ask & listen**
"What are you hoping to get from social media?" Let them talk. Their words become your pitch.
- 2 Say the gap back to them**
"So you want more bookings, but you're posting twice a month with no plan."
- 3 Offer ONE package**
One clear package, one monthly price. Don't drown them in options.
- 4 Frame the price as ROI**
"One new customer a month covers this — and I'll aim for a lot more than one."
- 5 Close it**
"Shall we start Monday? I'll send everything over." Then stop talking.

The secret: say your price, then shut up. Whoever speaks first "loses" — let them sit with it. You're solving a real problem; act like it.

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DELIVER LIKE A PRO

Run it like a machine.

Winning the client is the hard bit. Keeping them is easy if you set it up properly from day one. Here's my exact onboarding and monthly flow.

Onboarding checklist (do all of it)

- ✓ **Contract signed** & first invoice paid **before** any work.
- ✓ **Access** — added as a manager (never post from your own login).
- ✓ **Brand basics** — logo, colours, fonts, tone, do's & don'ts.
- ✓ **Month-one content plan** approved.
- ✓ **A filming day** booked to bank a batch of content.

The monthly flow

Week	What you do
1	Plan the month, film/gather, get it approved
2–3	Schedule & post, manage comments & DMs
4	Engage, check numbers, plan next month
End	Send the report, invoice for next month

Batch across clients: all planning on one day, all editing on another. Systems are how you handle 5+ clients without losing your mind.

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KEEP THEM

Results = they never leave.

A client who stays is money every single month with no re-selling. The two things that keep them: showing results, and communicating so they never wonder what they're paying for.

The monthly report (keep it simple)

- ✦ **Reach & views** — up or down vs last month.
- ✦ **Follower growth** & engagement.
- ✦ **Best posts** — what worked and why.
- ✦ **Leads / bookings / clicks** — the number they actually care about.
- ✦ **Next month's plan** — always end looking forward.

Over-communicate. A quick weekly "here's what's going out this week" message makes clients feel looked after — and stops them ever questioning the invoice.

Then grow the account (and the invoice)

- ✦ Once you're delivering, **upsell**: ads, a second platform, a filming day, a website.
- ✦ Ask happy clients for a **testimonial and a referral** — your next clients come from your current ones.



Want my client report template & onboarding checklist? **DM @lou1sethomson.**

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A woman with long brown hair and blue eyes, wearing a black polka-dot crop top with a white bow at the waist and a matching skirt, stands against a rough stone wall. She is looking directly at the camera with a slight smile. The lighting is warm and focused on her, creating a soft glow. The background is a textured stone wall with some wooden beams visible on the right side.

MODULE 05

Build a Social Media Agency

When you're maxed out on clients, you don't work more hours — you build a company. Systems, a small team, delivery that runs without you. This is how a freelancer becomes an agency owner who earns while they sleep.

Freelancer → agency

Systems

Hire a team

Scale delivery





FREELANCER → AGENCY

From doing it to owning it.

A freelancer sells their hours. An agency sells an outcome and delivers it with a team and systems. That's how you smash through the "there aren't enough hours" ceiling — and it's simpler than it sounds.

The 4 stages

1

Solo

You do everything for 1–3 clients. Prove you get results.

2

Systemised

You turn how you work into repeatable processes.

3

Small team

You outsource tasks — editing first, then posting — and manage instead of do.

4

Agency

A team delivers, you sell & lead. 10+ clients, real profit.

Niche the agency. "Social media for gyms" beats "for anyone." You get referrals, reuse ideas across clients, and charge more as the specialist.



Building an agency and want a shortcut? **DM @lou1sethomson** — it's exactly what we help creators set up.

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Want more, or want it done for you? **DM @lou1sethomson**

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SYSTEMS & SOPS

Make yourself replaceable.

Systems are what let you hand work over without the quality dropping. Every time you do a task, write down how you did it — that's an SOP, and it's the backbone of a business that can run without you glued to it.

The core systems to build

- ✦ **Onboarding** — the exact steps from "yes" to first post.
- ✦ **Content production** — plan → film → edit → approve → schedule.
- ✦ **Reporting** — one template, filled in monthly.
- ✦ **Communication** — when and how you update clients.

Tools that run the machine

- ✦ **Notion / Trello / ClickUp** — your client & content hub.
- ✦ **Later / Metricool** — schedule without logging in daily.
- ✦ **Google Drive** — every client's content, organised.
- ✦ **Loom** — record how you do a thing once, train anyone off it.

My rule: if I've done it twice, I write the SOP. Boring for an afternoon, life-changing forever.

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HIRE YOUR TEAM

Buy back your time.

You can't scale on your own — and you don't have to. You hire in the right order, starting with the tasks you hate, and each hire pays for themselves by freeing you up to win more clients.

Who to hire, in order

Hire	Takes over	Rough cost
1. Video editor	The biggest time-drain	£5–£20 / video
2. Virtual assistant	Scheduling, DMs, admin	£4–£12 / hour
3. Filmer/creator	Client filming days	Per day / freelance
4. Account manager	Running clients daily	Salary / %

Where to find them

- ✦ **Upwork, Fiverr, OnlineJobs.ph** — freelancers & VAs.
- ✦ **Instagram/TikTok** — hire editors whose work you already rate.
- ✦ **Your own audience** — your followers often want to work with you.

Hire freelance first. Start per-task, never salaried. Add hours as the client list grows — never the other way round.

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SCALE DELIVERY

Quality with 10+ clients.

The danger as you grow is quality slipping. Systems plus batching keep every client feeling like your only client — even when you've got twenty.

Batch everything

- ✦ **Theme your days** — Mon plan all clients, Tue film, Wed edit, Thu schedule, Fri engage & report.
- ✦ **Templatise** — reuse formats and structures across clients (not the actual content).
- ✦ **Schedule a month ahead** so nothing's ever last-minute.

Keep them happy at scale

- ✦ **Same-day replies** — speed feels like care.
- ✦ **Monthly report + a quick Loom** walking them through it.
- ✦ **One surprise extra a month** — under-promise, over-deliver.

10 clients × £1,000 = £10k/month — mostly delivered by your team.

That's the whole point of an agency: your income stops being tied to your hours.

LT





MODULE 06

Branding That Sells

People buy from brands they trust. This is how to build a look and a voice — for you and for your clients — that feels premium, gets remembered, and lets you charge more.

Foundations

Visual identity

Voice & positioning



FOUNDATIONS

A brand is a feeling.

Your brand is what people feel when they see your name. Get the fundamentals right and you become memorable, recommendable and premium — which means you get to charge more.

The five foundations

- ✦ **Purpose** — what you stand for and who you help.
- ✦ **Personality** — bold? warm? luxe? playful? expert?
- ✦ **Promise** — the result people get from you.
- ✦ **Look** — colours, fonts, imagery (next page).
- ✦ **Voice** — how you sound in captions and DMs.

Consistency is the whole trick. Same colours, same tone, same energy everywhere. Repetition builds recognition, and recognition builds trust — and trust is what people actually pay for.

People don't buy the best product. They buy the brand they trust the most.

Do this now: write three words for how you want people to feel about you. Everything you make should match them.

LT





VISUAL IDENTITY

Your look, locked in.

A simple, consistent look makes you seem established even on day one. You only need a few decisions — then you repeat them forever and never think about it again.

Colours

- ✦ Pick **1 main, 1 accent, 1–2 neutrals**.
- ✦ Same ones across posts, highlights, your site.
- ✦ Colour = instant recognition in a busy feed.

Fonts

- ✦ One characterful **heading** font.
- ✦ One clean **body** font.
- ✦ Never more than two — more looks messy.

The starter brand kit

- ✓ **Logo / wordmark** — even just your name in your font.
- ✓ **Colour palette** — hex codes saved.
- ✓ **2 fonts** — heading + body.
- ✓ **Profile photo & highlight covers** — on brand.
- ✓ **2 reusable post templates**.

Tool tip: build the whole kit free in **Canva** and save it as a Brand Kit, so every design you ever make stays consistent automatically.

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VOICE & POSITIONING

Sound worth following.

Your words do as much as your visuals. A clear voice and a sharp bio turn a random profile-visit into a follow — or an enquiry.

Find your voice

- ✦ Write like you **talk** — read it out loud; if it sounds stiff, rewrite it.
- ✦ Pick a lane: warm & relatable, bold & direct, or calm & expert.
- ✦ Be consistent so people can "hear" you.

The bio formula

[Who you help] + [what you help them do] + [proof/personality] + [one CTA].

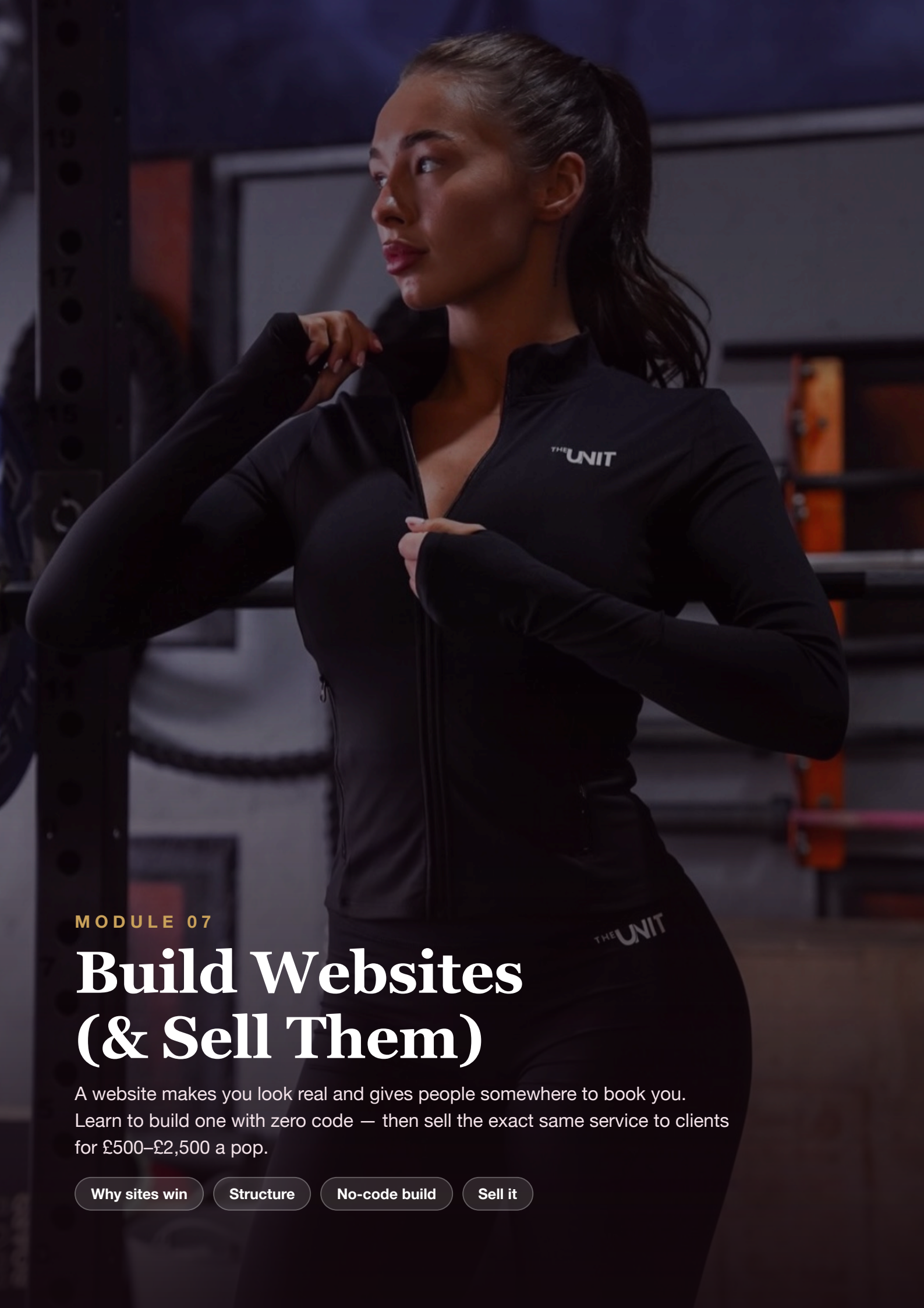
e.g. "Helping local gyms fill classes with scroll-stopping content 💪 300k+ views for clients · DM 'GROW'."

Be the obvious choice

- ✦ **Niche + result** beats "I do social media." Specific gets booked.
- ✦ **Show proof** the moment you have any — results, testimonials, before/after.
- ✦ **One clear next step** everywhere (follow, DM a word, tap the link).

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MODULE 07

Build Websites (& Sell Them)

A website makes you look real and gives people somewhere to book you.
Learn to build one with zero code — then sell the exact same service to clients
for £500–£2,500 a pop.

Why sites win

Structure

No-code build

Sell it



WHY & WHAT

Every brand needs a home.

Social media is rented land — the platform owns it and the rules change overnight. A website is land you **own**. It's where people book you, buy from you, and take you seriously — and it's a service you can sell to every single client.

What a good site does

- ✦ **Builds trust** — a real site says "real business."
- ✦ **Captures leads** — enquiry forms, email sign-ups.
- ✦ **Sells 24/7** — services, products, bookings.
- ✦ **Shows proof** — portfolio, testimonials, results.

The pages nearly every site needs

Page	Its job
Home	Hook, what you do, proof, one clear CTA
About	Story & trust — why you
Services / Shop	What they buy & the next step
Portfolio	Results & testimonials
Contact / Book	Form, calendar, socials

One golden rule: every page points to ONE clear action — book, buy, or enquire. Confused people don't buy.

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BUILD IT (NO CODE)

Live in a weekend.

You do not need to code. Modern drag-and-drop builders mean anyone can make a beautiful, professional site. Here's the exact workflow.

Pick a builder

Wix / Squarespace

Easiest for beginners. Gorgeous templates, drag-and-drop, hosting built in.

Framer / Carrd

Sleek & modern. Carrd is perfect (and cheap) for one-pagers.

Shopify

When they're selling products.

The build steps

1 Start from a template

Pick one close to the vibe — never start from blank.

2 Swap in the brand

Colours, fonts, logo, photos, real words.

3 Write clear copy

Benefit-led headlines, short paragraphs, buttons everywhere.

4 Connect the essentials

Domain, contact form, socials, booking/payment.

5 Check mobile & launch

Most visitors are on a phone — test it there first.

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SELL IT

Turn it into £500–£2,500.

Once you can build one site, you can build them for clients — and it pairs perfectly with social media management. Same clients, extra income, barely any extra effort.

Website packages

Package	Included	Price
One-pager	Single scrolling page, form, socials	£400–£800
Business site	4–6 pages, copy, branding, SEO basics	£900–£2,500
Online shop	Products, payments, setup & training	£2,500–£6,000
Care plan	Hosting, updates & edits (recurring)	£30–£100/mo

The care plan is the gold. Build it once, then charge monthly to look after it — recurring income sat on top of the build fee.

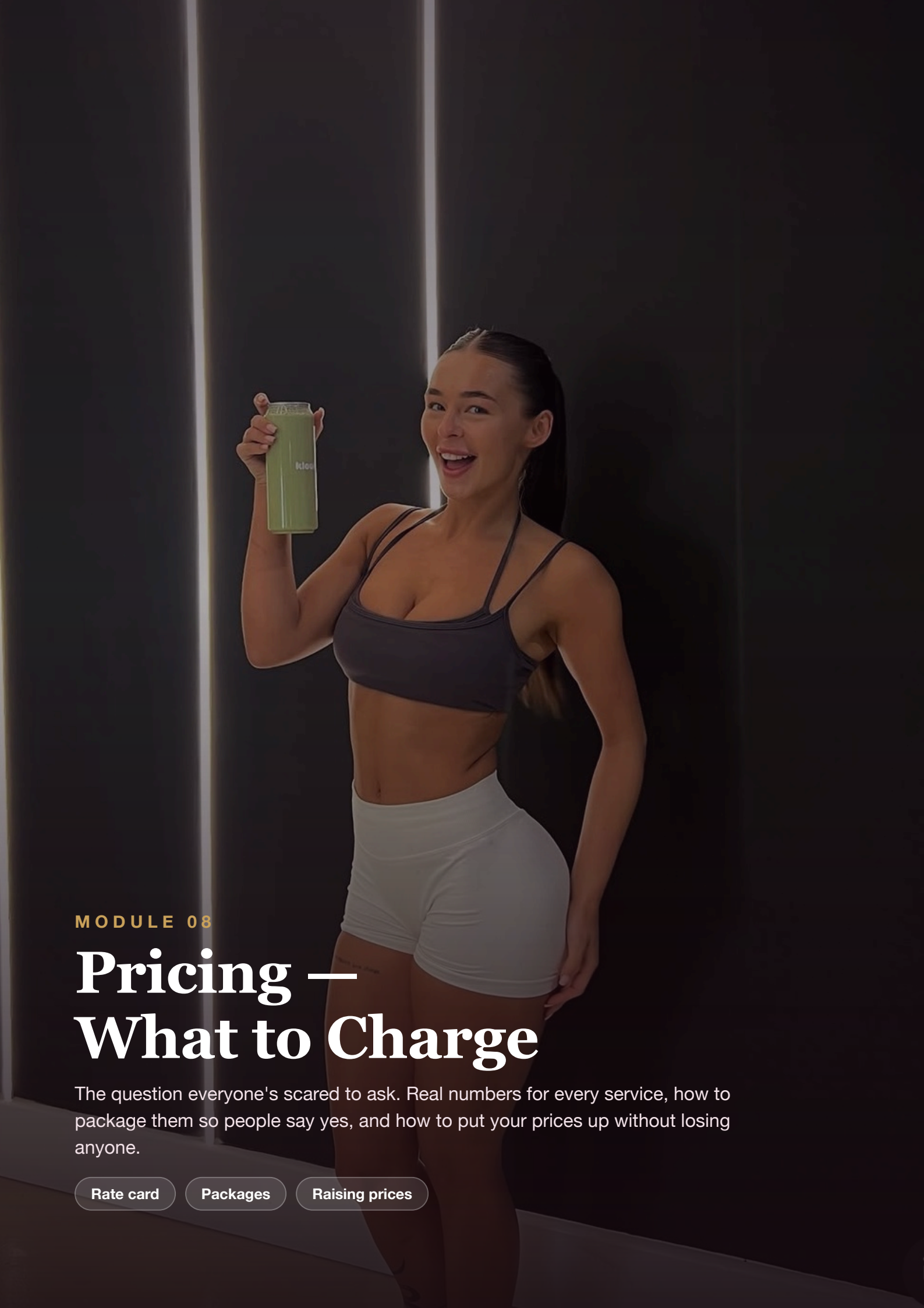
- ✦ **Bundle it:** "Website + social media management" is an easy, high-value yes.
- ✦ **Show, don't tell:** rebuild a local business's weak site as a free demo — it becomes your portfolio and your pitch.



Don't want to build it yourself? My team builds sites for creators & businesses — **DM @lou1sethomson.**

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A woman with long dark hair, wearing a dark grey sports bra and white high-waisted shorts, is smiling and holding a green smoothie in a clear bottle. The bottle has the word 'klos' on it. She is standing in front of a dark background with two vertical light streaks.

MODULE 08

Pricing — What to Charge

The question everyone's scared to ask. Real numbers for every service, how to package them so people say yes, and how to put your prices up without losing anyone.

Rate card

Packages

Raising prices



THE RATE CARD

What to actually charge.

Undercharging is the number one mistake — I did it for way too long. Here are real market ranges. Start near the lower end while you build proof, then put them up every few clients (next page).

Service	What it is	Price
SMM — Starter	1 platform, ~12 posts/mo	£400–£600/mo
SMM — Growth	2 platforms, reels, engagement	£800–£1,200/mo
SMM — Premium	Full management + strategy	£1,500–£3,000/mo
UGC video	Single branded video	£120–£300
Brand deal post	Per platform (scales with reach)	£250–£2,000+
Content / filming day	Batch of photo & video	£400–£800
Website	One-pager → business site	£400–£2,500
Branding kit	Logo, colours, fonts, templates	£250–£1,500
Coaching	Per hour	£60–£150/hr

Price on value, not hours. A post that brings a client £5,000 is worth way more than the 30 minutes it took you. Charge for the result.

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PACKAGES

Sell outcomes, not tasks.

Never sell "posts." Sell a **package** with a clear outcome and a monthly price. Packages are easier to buy, easier to deliver, and way more profitable.

Build three tiers

Good

The essentials at an easy-yes price. Gets them in.

£400–£600/mo

Better

Your main offer — most people pick this.

£800–£1,200/mo

Best

Everything done for them. Anchors your pricing.

£1,500–£3,000/mo

The middle always wins. Most people choose the middle option — so put your best offer there and price the others around it to make it the obvious value.

Why retainers change your life

- ♦ **Predictable** — you start every month already earning.
- ♦ **Less selling** — win a client once, get paid for months.
- ♦ **It compounds** — 5 clients at £1,000 = £5,000/mo, every month.

Do this now: write your three packages — names, what's in them, prices. Done? You're ready to pitch.

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RAISING PRICES

Charge more, keep everyone.

Your prices should go up as you get better and busier — but people freeze here, terrified of scaring clients off. Here's how to do it calmly and keep them all.

When to put prices up

- ✦ **Every few new clients** — new clients come in at the higher rate, existing ones stay (for now).
- ✦ **When you're fully booked** — demand > supply means raise the price, not the hours.
- ✦ **When you've got proof** — results and testimonials justify a higher number.

How to tell existing clients

"Hi [name], from [date] my rate for this package is moving to £[X]/mo. It reflects the results we've been getting and the extra I've been adding. I'd love to keep working together — happy to talk it through."

- ✦ **Give notice** (30 days), be calm, don't apologise.
- ✦ Most stay — you're already delivering, and switching is a hassle for them.
- ✦ If one leaves, the higher rate usually makes up for it with fewer clients anyway.

Charging more attracts BETTER clients.

Cheap attracts nightmares. Higher prices bring people who value the work and cause less hassle. Every time.

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MODULE 09

Set Up Your Business & Get Paid

The unsexy bit that makes it real. Registering, a business bank account, taking payments properly, staying on top of tax, and protecting yourself with contracts. Do this and you're a business — not a hobby that occasionally gets paid.

Register

Banking & payments

Invoicing

Tax

Contracts

REGISTER

Make it official.

You can start earning today, but once money's coming in you set up properly. It's simpler and cheaper than people fear (this is UK — check your own country's rules).

Sole trader vs limited company

	Sole trader	Ltd company
Setup	Register with HMRC, free, 10 min	Companies House (~£50)
Best for	Starting out, lower income	Higher income, protection
Admin	Simple — one tax return	More, an accountant helps
Liability	You & the business are one	Personal assets protected

Simple path: start as a **sole trader** to keep it easy. Switch to a **limited company** once you're earning well (often ~£30k+) — your accountant will tell you when it's worth it.

- ✦ **Pick a name** — yours works fine ("Louise Thomson" / "LT Social").
- ✦ **Register as self-employed** with HMRC.
- ✦ **Don't over-complicate it** — no office, no staff, nothing fancy needed to start.

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BANKING & PAYMENTS

How to take money properly.

Keep business money separate from personal from day one — it makes tax painless and looks professional. Then set up ways to get paid that people trust and that chase themselves.

Get a business bank account

- ✦ **Free digital banks** — Starling, Tide, Monzo Business — open from your phone in minutes.
- ✦ **One account for all business in & out** — never mix with personal.

Ways to get paid

Method	Best for	Notes
Stripe	Cards, invoices, subscriptions	Pro, automatic, small fee
PayPal / Wise	Quick & international	Easy, trusted
GoCardless / direct debit	Monthly retainers	Auto-collects — no chasing
Bank transfer	Simple one-offs	No fees, but manual

For retainers, use auto-collection (a Stripe subscription or direct debit). You get paid the same day every month without lifting a finger — this is the secret to stress-free recurring income.

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INVOICING

Get paid on time, every time.

Clear invoicing gets you paid faster and makes you look legit. Takes minutes with the right tool — and it kills the awkward "have you paid yet?" chase.

Invoice like a pro

- ✓ **Invoice upfront** — payment before the month's work (or 50% deposit on projects).
- ✓ **Free software** — Wave, Stripe, PayPal auto-generate invoices.
- ✓ **Clear terms** — "due on receipt" or "within 7 days", stated on it.
- ✓ **Auto-reminders** — the tool chases late payers for you.
- ✓ **Number & save every one** — you'll need them at tax time.

What goes on it

- ✦ Your name/business & contact, an invoice number & date.
- ✦ The client, what you did, the amount & due date.
- ✦ How to pay — bank details or a payment link.

Deposits protect you. Always take money up front on new clients and projects — it filters out time-wasters and locks in your income.

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TAX & MONEY

Keep what you earn.

Not anyone's favourite subject — but staying on top of it keeps you free and stress-free. The basics are genuinely simple once you set them up.

The essentials

- ✦ **Put money aside for tax** — save ~**20–30%** of profit into a separate pot as you earn. Never touch it.
- ✦ **Track income & expenses** — a free tool (Wave) or even a spreadsheet.
- ✦ **Claim your expenses** — phone, laptop, subscriptions, ring light, travel, a bit of home use — they lower your tax bill.
- ✦ **File on time** — UK self-assessment is due 31 January. Don't be late.

When to get an accountant

- ✦ Once you're earning steadily, an accountant (~£30–£100/mo) saves you more than they cost.
- ✦ They do your tax, tell you what to claim, and free your time to earn.
- ✦ **Watch the VAT threshold** (£90k in the UK) — they'll guide you as you grow.

Do this today: set up a second bank "pot" and send 25% into it every time you're paid. Future-you never gets a nasty surprise.

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CONTRACTS & LEGAL

Protect yourself.

A simple contract protects you, sets expectations and makes you look serious. You don't need a lawyer for a basic one — you need the right things written down.

Every client contract should cover

- ✦ **Scope** — exactly what's in, and what costs extra.
- ✦ **Price & payment terms** — amount, dates, method, late fees.
- ✦ **Term & cancellation** — rolling monthly, 30 days' notice.
- ✦ **Ownership & access** — who owns content and logins.
- ✦ **Approvals & revisions** — how many, and turnaround.

Other bases to cover

- ✦ **#ad disclosure** — always label paid partnerships (it's the law).
- ✦ **Data / GDPR** — handle client logins & customer data responsibly.
- ✦ **Insurance** — professional indemnity is cheap and worth it as you grow.



Want a ready-to-use contract, invoice & onboarding pack? **DM @lou1sethomson.**

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A woman with long brown hair and blue eyes is posing in a black and white bikini by a swimming pool. She is looking towards the camera with a slight smile. The background shows a pool with blue water, a concrete edge, and some greenery.

MODULE 10

Grow, Monetise & Scale

The honest version of how the money actually builds — the real 12-month story with the dips and all — then how to stack streams, land brand deals, and build income that grows even when you're not posting.

The real story

The breakdown

Income streams

Brand deals

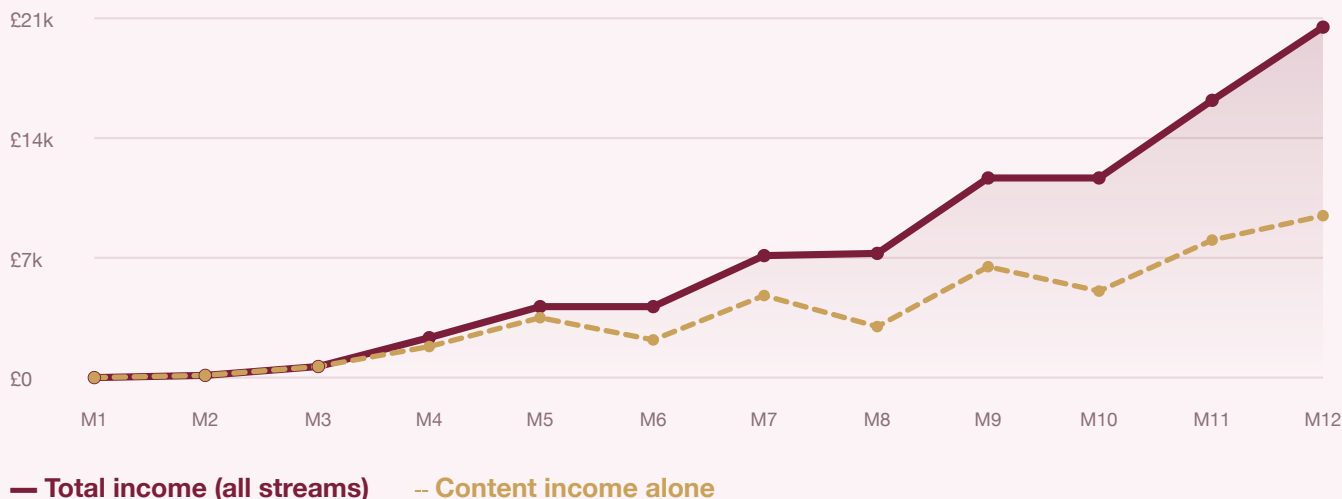
Scale



HOW IT REALLY WENT

£0 to £20k — the real story.

Forget the fake "straight line up" graphs. Here's how it **actually** went — messy, with real dips in the months I posted less. The gold line is content income on its own. The wine line is my **total** once I built other streams.



See the gold dips at **months 6, 8 and 10**? That's me travelling, getting busy, or just not posting enough — and content income fell hard. But look at the wine line: the **total barely flinched**. That's not luck. That's diversification doing its job.

Why the total kept climbing

- ✦ **Content is a rollercoaster** — deals and views need you posting. Miss a few weeks and it drops.
- ✦ **So I built income that doesn't need me to post** — social media management (paid monthly either way), website builds, SEO for local businesses, and my own products.
- ✦ **Those streams are recurring or independent** — they fill every dip and stack on top.

The lesson in one line: don't build a bigger content income — build **more income streams**.

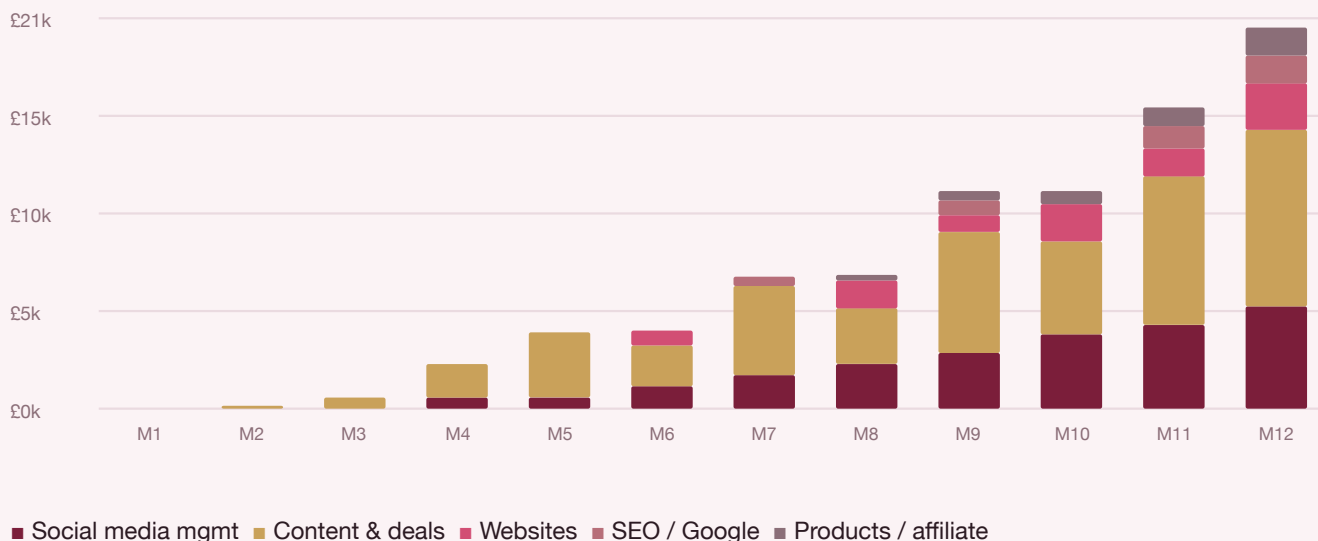
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THE BREAKDOWN

How the streams stacked up.

Same 12 months, broken down by where the money came from. Watch the **gold (content)** wobble while the recurring streams grow underneath it — that's what carried the total to £20k+.



How each stream behaves

Stream	Behaviour	Role
Content & deals	Volatile, high ceiling	Big wins, drops when you don't post
Social media mgmt	Recurring, predictable	The backbone — paid monthly regardless
Websites	Lumpy projects + care plans	Chunky cash + a recurring tail
SEO / Google	Project + retainer	Easy add-on for local clients
Products	Passive, compounding	Small, grows while you sleep

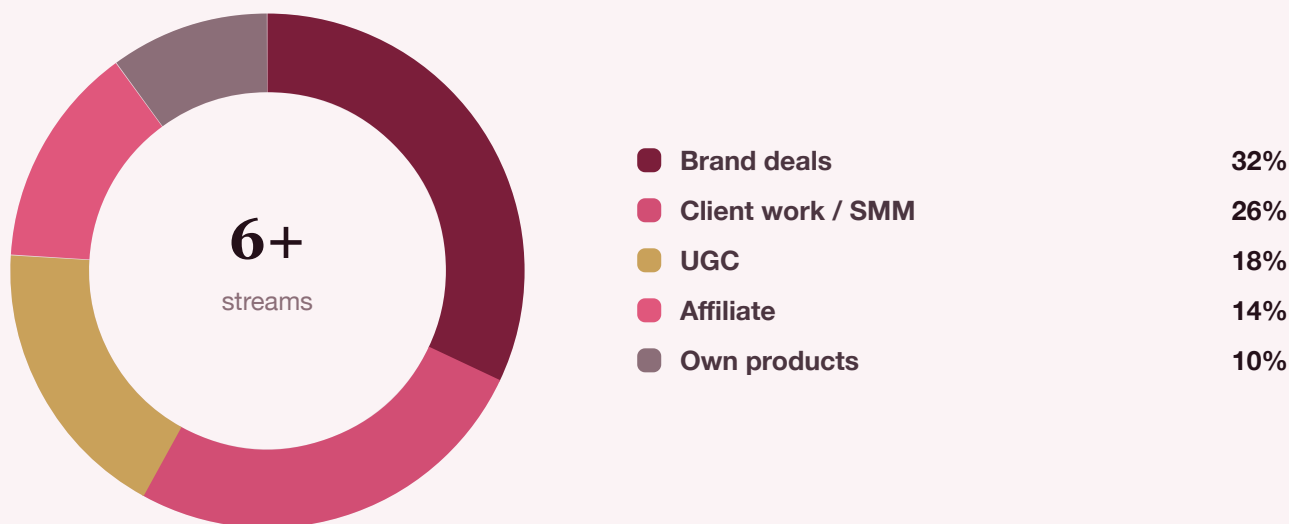
Build the recurring ones first. Management & care plans pay you on the quiet months — that stability is what lets you take swings on content without fear.



INCOME STREAMS

Never rely on one payday.

The creators who last don't have one income — they've got several, feeding each other. Here's the mix and roughly how it balances out for me now.



- ✦ **Brand deals** — paid posts; scale with your reach.
- ✦ **Client work** — SMM & websites; your reliable base.
- ✦ **UGC** — content for brands you don't even post yourself.
- ✦ **Affiliate** — a cut on every sale through your link.
- ✦ **Your own products** — guides, presets, courses; you keep nearly all of it.

Add them one at a time. Get one stream working before you start the next — don't spread yourself thin.

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BRAND DEALS & PASSIVE

Get paid — even in your sleep.

Two things here: how to land brand deals (you don't need millions of followers), and why your old content keeps paying you long after you've posted it.

Landing brand deals

- ✦ **Tag & feature brands you love** — show them what working with you looks like.
- ✦ **Pitch directly** — a short confident email + a one-page media kit (who you are, your stats, past work, rates).
- ✦ **Know your worth** — charge per deliverable and per platform; rates rise as your reach does.

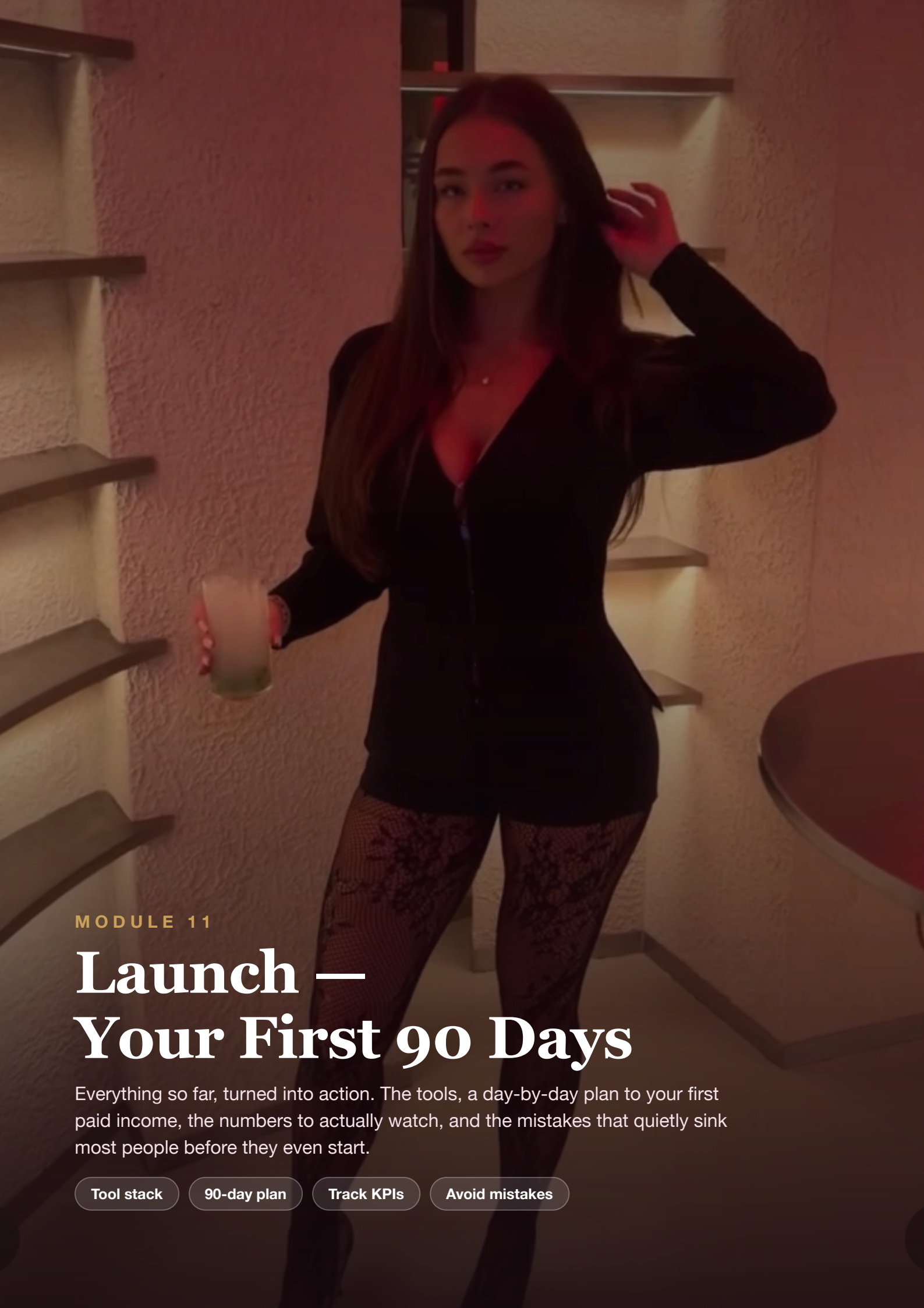
"Hi [brand], I'm [name] — I create [niche] content for [audience]. Recent posts hit [reach]. Your product's a perfect fit — I'd love to make [idea]. Media kit attached. Open to a collab?"

Earn while you sleep

- ✦ **Evergreen content keeps selling** — a video that did well stays out there; people find it and buy weeks later.
- ✦ **Affiliate links & products** earn 24/7 with no new work.
- ✦ **It compounds** — as your audience grows, old posts reach that bigger audience too. Growth stacks on growth.

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MODULE 11

Launch — Your First 90 Days

Everything so far, turned into action. The tools, a day-by-day plan to your first paid income, the numbers to actually watch, and the mistakes that quietly sink most people before they even start.

Tool stack

90-day plan

Track KPIs

Avoid mistakes



TOOL STACK

Everything you need (mostly free).

You can run this whole thing from your phone and a laptop. Here's the full kit — start with the free ones, add the rest only when you actually need them.

Create

- ✦ **CapCut / InShot** — editing
- ✦ **Canva** — graphics & branding
- ✦ **Lightroom** — photos

Manage

- ✦ **Later / Metricool** — schedule & analytics
- ✦ **Notion / Trello** — clients & content
- ✦ **Google Drive** — storage

Get paid

- ✦ **Starling / Tide** — business bank
- ✦ **Stripe / PayPal / Wave** — invoices

Grow

- ✦ **ChatGPT** — ideas, captions, outreach
- ✦ **Wix / Squarespace / Carrd** — websites
- ✦ **Stan / Beacons** — link-in-bio & products

Don't buy everything. Start with CapCut, Canva, a free scheduler, a free business bank and Wave. That's a whole business, for £0.

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90-DAY PLAN

The exact plan.

This is how you turn the whole guide into money. Follow it and in three months you'll have posted consistently, pitched real clients, and set up to get paid.

Phase	Focus	Goal
Days 1–7	Pick path & niche, set up profile & bio, write 10 hooks	Ready to launch
Days 8–30	Post daily, nail the hook, batch content	First content out, first followers
Days 31–60	Build a brand kit & a demo site, list your packages, start outreach	First calls booked
Days 61–90	Close your first client, deliver, get a testimonial, raise prices	First paid income 🎉

Consistency beats talent. Every single time.

The people who win aren't the most gifted — they're the ones who kept posting and kept pitching when everyone else quit.

Do this now: put these four phases in your calendar with a start date. Today's date. Not "next Monday."

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TRACK YOUR NUMBERS

What gets measured grows.

You don't need to obsess over analytics — but check a few numbers weekly so you know what's working and can do more of it.

Your weekly dashboard

Reach

How many people saw you — top of everything

Engagement

Saves, shares, comments — quality of attention

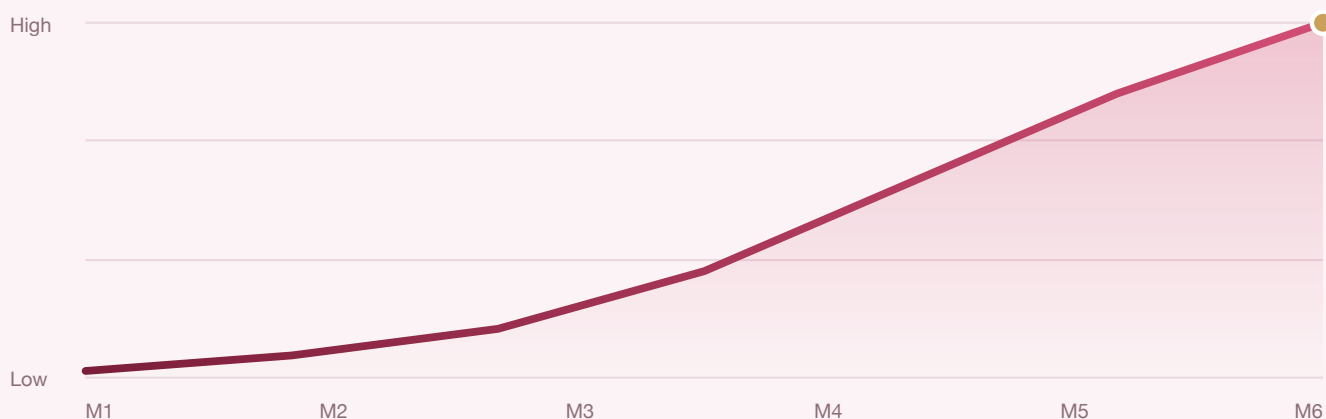
Followers

Growth rate, not just the total

Income

Leads, clients & £ — the one that counts

6 months of consistent effort



It's a curve, not a line. The first weeks feel slow — that's completely normal. Momentum compounds. Keep going and it takes off.

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MISTAKES TO AVOID

Don't trip over these.

Most people who quit didn't fail at the work — they made avoidable mistakes and lost heart. Dodge these and you're already ahead of 90% of beginners.

The big ones

- ✦ **Waiting to be "ready."** Perfect never comes. Post the imperfect video today.
- ✦ **Posting randomly.** No niche, no plan, no consistency = no growth. Use a system.
- ✦ **Undercharging.** Cheap attracts nightmare clients and burns you out.
- ✦ **No contract or deposit.** Fastest way to get burned. Always both.
- ✦ **Chasing followers, not income.** A small engaged audience out-earns a big passive one.
- ✦ **Quitting at week 3.** It's always slow right before it isn't.
- ✦ **Doing everything alone.** Systemise and outsource before you burn out.

The real mistake is treating this like a hobby. Treat it like the business it is — show up daily, track the numbers, get paid properly — and it pays you like one.



Stuck on your next step? **DM @lou1sethomson** — one message could save you months.

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MODULE 12

Done For You & AI

Don't fancy doing it yourself? My team does the lot — content, management, websites, branding and full AI systems. Or learn AI directly from my engineer and become genuinely unstoppable. This is the shortcut.

[Done-for-you](#)

[Websites \(no Shopify needed\)](#)

[AI engineering](#)

[Learn AI](#)





DONE FOR YOU

Or... we just do it all.

This guide shows you how to do it yourself — but plenty of people and businesses would rather hand it over. That's exactly what my team's for. You focus on your life or your business; we run the rest.

What we take off your plate

- ◆ **Content** — filmed, edited, posted
- ◆ **Full social media management**
- ◆ **Branding** — identity & templates
- ◆ **Paid ads** — set up & run
- ◆ **Websites & shops** — built for you
- ◆ **Strategy** — a plan that grows you
- ◆ **Reporting** — clear results monthly
- ◆ **Whatever you need** — just ask

No Shopify? No problem. Don't want to learn Shopify, editing software or website builders? You don't have to. We build and run it all — you never touch the tech.



Want it done for you? Tell us your goal and we'll build the plan. **DM @lou1sethomson** for a quote.

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AI THAT DOES THE WORK

A full AI engineering team.

Here's what makes us different: behind me is a **full team of AI engineers** who can build almost anything. AI isn't the future — it's how smart creators and businesses are winning right now, while everyone else is asleep on it.

What we can build you



AI automation

Systems that handle the repetitive stuff — replies, DMs, scheduling, follow-up — 24/7.



Chatbots & voice agents

AI that answers customers, books appointments and sells, on your site or phone.



Custom AI tools

Content engines, dashboards, apps — built around your business.

- ✦ **Save hours a week** — let AI do the busywork so you create and sell.
- ✦ **Scale without hiring** — one AI system can do the work of a small team.
- ✦ **Be early** — most of your competition hasn't caught on yet.



Got an idea or a bottleneck you want gone? **DM @lou1sethomson** — my AI team will tell you what's possible.

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LEARN AI DIRECT

Learn AI from my engineer.

Want to learn this yourself and be genuinely unstoppable? You can learn AI **directly with my AI engineer** — the same person who builds our systems. It's the single most valuable skill you can pick up right now.

What you'll learn

- ✦ **Prompting** — get world-class results from AI every time.
- ✦ **Automate your content** — ideas, scripts, captions, repurposing, at speed.
- ✦ **Build AI tools & automations** — even with zero coding background.
- ✦ **Run a business with AI** — admin, marketing, customer service, sales.

Why it matters: the people who learn AI now will out-earn and out-work everyone who doesn't. Learning it straight from an engineer who builds real systems is the fastest way in.

Ways to learn

1:1 sessions

Personal training on exactly what you want to build.

Group courses

Step-by-step, from scratch.

In the Academy

AI modules built right in.



Ready to learn AI with my engineer? **DM @lou1sethomson** to join the next intake.

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Want more, or want it done for you? **DM @lou1sethomson**

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SWIPE FILE

Steal these — they work.

Save this page. These are plug-and-play starting points for the things you'll do most — swap in your own words and go.

10 hooks to open any video

- ◆ "Stop doing this if you want to grow."
- ◆ "POV: you finally..."
- ◆ "Nobody tells you this about..."
- ◆ "The fastest way to..."
- ◆ "How I went from ___ to ___."
- ◆ "I tried ___ for 30 days."
- ◆ "3 things I wish I knew before..."
- ◆ "This mistake is costing you ___."
- ◆ "Watch this before you..."
- ◆ "Save this if you..."

Client outreach DM

"Hi [name], love what you do at [business]! I put together a couple of quick content ideas that could bring you more [result] — want me to send them over? No strings, I just work with local businesses like yours."

Brand-deal pitch

"Hi [brand], I'm [name] — I create [niche] content for [audience]. Recent posts hit [reach]. Your product's a perfect fit — I'd love to make [idea]. Media kit attached. Open to a collab?"



Want the full templates pack — contract, invoice, media kit & 50 hooks? **DM**
@lou1sethomson.

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Want more, or want it done for you? **DM @lou1sethomson**

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RESOURCES

Everything in one place.

The tools I actually use and recommend — most are free. Don't buy everything; start with the free ones and add as you grow.

Create

- ✦ **CapCut / InShot** — video
- ✦ **Canva** — graphics & branding
- ✦ **Lightroom** — photos

Plan & manage

- ✦ **Notion / Trello** — clients & content
- ✦ **Later / Metricool** — scheduling
- ✦ **Google Drive** — storage

Get paid & run it

- ✦ **Starling / Tide** — business bank
- ✦ **Stripe / PayPal / Wave** — invoices
- ✦ **GoCardless** — retainer direct debits

Grow & build

- ✦ **ChatGPT** — ideas & captions
- ✦ **Wix / Squarespace / Carrd** — sites
- ✦ **Stan / Beacons** — link-in-bio

Your starter stack (all free): CapCut + Canva + a scheduler + a free business bank + Wave for invoices. That's a whole business, for £0.

LT





Louise Thomson
THE PLAYBOOK

YOU'VE GOT THE MAP — NOW LET'S WALK IT TOGETHER

Let's do this together.

This playbook gives you the what. My Academy gives you the how — with me — step by step, with feedback, templates, and a community doing it right alongside you.



The Louise Thomson Academy is opening soon.

Full video training on everything in this guide — content, social media management, SEO, branding, websites, pricing, the business side and AI — plus live Q&As, a resource vault, and a bookable creator directory once you're ready to get paid. **Follow me and turn on notifications** to be first in — early members get the best price.

Join the waitlist — follow @lou1sethomson



Instagram — [instagram.com/lou1sethomson](https://www.instagram.com/lou1sethomson)



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